

Climate, Wildlife, Animal Science, and Clean Tech: The Week of September 6-12, 2026

This week's clearest throughline was federal water and energy policy pulling in two directions at once — a court striking down a Trump administration order that kept an aging coal plant running, while EPA and the Army Corps separately proposed narrowing which streams and wetlands the Clean Water Act protects. Elsewhere, Mozambique formally protected a “butterfly forest,” and researchers flagged a data gap in tropical insect conservation. Sourcing is noted throughout, since several items rely on claims from advocacy groups or single reports rather than settled fact.

Climate Policy

Court strikes down Trump order keeping a Michigan coal plant open. On September 11, a three-judge panel of the U.S. Court of Appeals for the D.C. Circuit unanimously vacated a Department of Energy order that had forced Consumers Energy's J.H. Campbell coal plant in West Olive, Michigan to keep running past its planned May 2025 retirement. The court found DOE's use of emergency powers under Section 202(c) of the Federal Power Act exceeded its authority, writing that “our reading of the text, structure, and history leaves us unpersuaded by DOE's sweeping conception of its ‘emergency’ authority.” Michigan regulators and grid operator MISO had already approved Consumers Energy's plan to retire the 60-year-old plant, but DOE has issued six successive 90-day emergency orders keeping it open since May 2025, citing grid reliability concerns; Michigan's attorney general put the cost of that extended operation at more than \$250 million through June 2026. The ruling applies only to the first of the six orders, and Consumers Energy said the plant will keep running for now under the current order while it reviews the decision; DOE faces separate legal challenges to each of the other orders.

EPA and the Army Corps propose narrowing Clean Water Act jurisdiction. On September 4, the two agencies issued a supplemental proposed rule that would further narrow the federal definition of “waters of the United States” (WOTUS) — the term that determines which streams and wetlands fall under Clean Water Act protection. The new option would replace a “wet season” standard proposed last November with a stricter “perennial” flow requirement, meaning a stream or wetland would generally need standing or continuously flowing water year-round to qualify for federal jurisdiction. EPA acknowledges in the proposal that most intermittent streams, and many currently-jurisdictional wetlands, would likely fail that test, with the largest effects expected in the arid West; the agencies frame the change as implementing the Supreme Court's 2023 *Sackett v. EPA* decision, which narrowed federal water jurisdiction. Public comments are open through October 9. Environmental advocacy group the League of Conservation Voters characterized the move more critically, saying it would “eliminate federal safeguards for nearly all our nation's freshwater wetlands and millions of miles of streams” — a characterization from an advocacy group rather than the agencies' own framing of the rule's scope.

A pipeline permit was overturned, and California closed its legislative session with a climate package. The 3rd U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals overturned a water quality permit for the Northeast Supply Enhancement pipeline, which would have carried natural gas under Raritan Bay from Long Island to New Jersey, ruling on September 8 that New Jersey’s environmental regulator had approved it “arbitrarily and capriciously” (per League of Conservation Voters’ summary of New Jersey Monitor reporting); the state must now reconsider the permit. Separately, California’s legislature closed its 2026 session this week having passed a package of bills — covering data-center energy-cost guardrails, building electrification, expanded solar access, and utility spending oversight — that now await Governor Newsom’s signature, according to the League of Conservation Voters and California-based advocacy group EnviroVoters.

Wildlife & Conservation

- **Mozambique formally protected a “butterfly forest.”** Mongabay reported September 10 that Mozambique’s government created the 9,341-hectare Mount Mabu Community Conservation Area via a ministerial decree published August 24, granting local communities stewardship over a mountain forest home to more than 200 butterfly species and high levels of endemism. Ecologist Julian Bayliss, who led surveys supporting the designation over 20 years, called it “a great relief.” The award and Mongabay’s profile fall in slightly different weeks — the decree itself is dated late August, while Mongabay’s coverage published this week.
- **A Nigerian conservationist was profiled after winning a 2026 Rolex Award.** Mongabay profiled Rachel Ikemeh on September 10, recognizing her work helping the critically endangered Niger Delta red colobus monkey recover through community-managed conservation areas in Nigeria’s oil-affected Niger Delta; the species’ population is estimated to have fallen from roughly 10,000 individuals in 1993 to only hundreds by 2013, though community protection has since helped it partially recover. The award itself was announced earlier this year; this week’s coverage is Mongabay’s feature on her work.
- **Indonesia’s underground peat fires intensified.** ScienceDaily reported September 6 that Indonesia’s peat fires — which can smolder underground for months and are especially destructive — are surging early in the 2026 fire season as a strengthening El Niño and severe drought dry out wetlands, continuing the wildfire and haze crisis reported in past weeks.

Animal Health & Field Science

- **Long-lived bats may avoid cancer through unusual immune strategies.** ScienceDaily reported September 11 that researchers found long-lived bat species combine powerful immune defenses with distinctive methods of eliminating damaged cells, a combination that may help explain how bats avoid cancer and disease across unusually long lifespans; researchers hope the mechanisms could eventually inform new approaches to human disease as well.
- **Britain’s wasps are disappearing.** Also September 11, ScienceDaily reported that Britain’s wasp populations have become mysteriously scarce this summer, with scientists suspecting an unusual combination of temperature swings,

heatwaves, and food shortages; the wasps that remain also appear unusually small.

- **Tropical insect conservation is under-studied relative to its importance.**

A study out of Monash University, covered by ScienceDaily September 9, found that global insect conservation research is disproportionately concentrated outside the tropics, even though more than 80% of insect species live there — a pattern researchers describe as “parachute science,” where research capacity and attention cluster in wealthier, better-studied regions rather than where the biodiversity actually is.

Clean Technology

- **A wave of solar-plus-storage financing and project news.** Per trade newsletter Energy Digest (September 8), European renewable developer Aukera secured a €460 million (\$534 million) structured credit facility to accelerate battery storage and renewable projects across five European markets; EPC Renewables and Energy Fiji Limited signed a memorandum of understanding to develop the 240-megawatt-hour Yaqara Solar & Battery Project in Fiji; and a Virginia school district began deploying solar-and-battery microgrids to keep power running during extreme weather events, part of a broader trend of communities building energy resilience into public facilities.

The Big Picture

The Campbell coal plant ruling and the WOTUS proposal are, in a sense, mirror images of each other: one is a court reining in an executive agency’s emergency powers over energy policy, the other is two agencies using ordinary rulemaking to narrow environmental jurisdiction that courts have already trimmed once via *Sackett*. Both will keep generating legal and political fights well past this week — DOE’s other five emergency orders remain in separate litigation, and the WOTUS comment period runs through early October. Away from that federal tug-of-war, Mozambique’s new conservation area and Rachel Ikemeh’s community-led work in Nigeria’s Niger Delta were reminders that some of the most durable conservation gains happen through local stewardship rather than national policy, while the insect research this week pointed at a quieter, structural problem: a huge share of the world’s biodiversity lives in places conservation science still doesn’t look at closely enough. None of this week’s threads are resolved; most will develop further in the weeks ahead.

Sources

Campbell coal plant ruling: U.S. Court of Appeals for the D.C. Circuit opinion, Sept. 11, 2026; Bloomberg/Energy Connects, “Court Overturns Trump Order to Keep Michigan Coal Plant Running,” Sept. 11, 2026; CNBC, “Federal appeals court blocks Trump administration bid to keep Michigan coal plant open,” Sept. 11, 2026; Inside Climate News, “Court Rules Against Trump Order to Keep Costly Michigan Coal Plant Running,” Sept. 11, 2026; Bridge Michigan, Sept. 11, 2026; Common Dreams, citing a Sierra Club cost tracker.

WOTUS supplemental proposal: EPA/Army Corps official fact sheet and

prepublication proposal, Sept. 4, 2026; National Law Review, “Federal Agencies Propose Additional Revisions to the Definition of ‘Waters of the United States,’” Sept. 9, 2026; Sidley Environmental, Health, and Safety Brief, Sept. 8, 2026; Agri-Pulse, Sept. 4, 2026; Bilzin Sumberg Florida Real Estate Development Digest; League of Conservation Voters, “This Week in Climate Action – September 11, 2026” (advocacy characterization).

Pipeline permit and California legislature: League of Conservation Voters, “This Week in Climate Action – September 11, 2026,” citing New Jersey Monitor (Sept. 8, 2026) and EnviroVoters.

Wildlife & conservation: Mongabay, “Mozambique protects Mount Mabu ‘butterfly forest,’” Sept. 10, 2026 (decree dated Aug. 24, 2026); Mongabay, “Nigeria’s Rachel Ikemeh wins Rolex Award for efforts to save rare red monkey,” Sept. 10, 2026; ScienceDaily, “Indonesia’s Most Dangerous Fires Are Burning Underground,” Sept. 6, 2026.

Animal health & field science: ScienceDaily — long-lived bat immune/cancer-avoidance study, Sept. 11, 2026; Britain wasp decline, Sept. 11, 2026; tropical insect “parachute science” study (Monash University), Sept. 9, 2026.

Clean technology: Energy Digest, Sept. 8, 2026 edition (Aukera financing, Fiji solar-battery MOU, Virginia school district microgrids).

Note: The Mozambique and Rachel Ikemeh items involve underlying decisions or awards from earlier in the year; this week’s coverage is Mongabay’s reporting/profile, which is dated and cited accordingly. The WOTUS item presents the agencies’ own framing alongside an advocacy group’s more critical characterization rather than treating either as the neutral description.

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